

سُورَةُ الزَّلْزَلَةِ



Sūrat az-Zalzalah

The Earthquake — an āyah-by-āyah tafsīr

Drawing on Ibn Kathīr · as-Sa'dī · al-Jalālayn · aṭ-Ṭabarī · al-Qurṭubī · al-Baghawī

The Sūrah at a glance

8

āyāt

99

in muṣḥaf order

30

juz' ('Ammā)

Madanī

per Ibn Kathīr; some say Makkī

Names of the sūrah

- Az-Zalzalah — “the Earthquake”, from āyah 1
- Idhā Zulzilat — its opening words
- Az-Zilzāl — another common name

Central theme

The earth will quake, give up what it holds and testify to what was done upon it. Then people come forth in groups to be shown their deeds — and not even an atom’s weight of good or evil is lost.

“The unique, all-encompassing āyah”

Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī & Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim — on the authority of Abū Hurayrah رضي الله عنه

The Prophet ﷺ described the reward for keeping horses, then was asked about donkeys. He said:

**“Nothing has been revealed to me about them except this unique, all-encompassing āyah:
*Whoever does an atom’s weight of good will see it,
and whoever does an atom’s weight of evil will see it.*”**

Al-jāmi‘ah al-fādhah

Jāmi‘ah: it gathers every deed, great or small.
Fādhah: unique — nothing else in the Qur’ān states the rule so completely.

Other virtue reports

That it “equals half the Qur’ān” (at-Tirmidhī) and similar reports have disputed chains — cite them with caution.

The tafsīr sources in this deck



Ibn Kathīr

d. 774 AH

Tafsīr al-Qur'ān al-'Aẓīm — explains Qur'ān by Qur'ān, then Sunnah, then the Companions and Tābi'ūn.



as-Sa'dī

d. 1376 AH

Taysīr al-Karīm ar-Raḥmān — concise, focused on meanings, guidance and practical lessons.



al-Jalālayn

al-Maḥallī & as-Suyūṭī

Tafsīr al-Jalālayn — a word-by-word gloss; brief and precise in its definitions.



Others

aṭ-Ṭabarī • al-Qurṭubī • al-Baghawī

Used for the range of early opinions, language and further points.

Note: tafsīr points are summarised and paraphrased in English — check against the Arabic originals before teaching.

Three movements in eight āyāt

1-3

The earth quakes

Its final, mighty shaking; it casts out its burdens; man cries out, “What is wrong with it?”

4-5

The earth speaks

It reports everything done upon it — because its Lord has commanded it to.

6-8

The reckoning

People come forth in scattered groups to be shown their deeds. Not an atom’s weight is lost.

Āyah 1 • The final earthquake



إِذَا زُلْزِلَتِ الْأَرْضُ زِلْزَالَهَا

When the earth is shaken with its [final] earthquake,

Ibn Kathīr

Ibn ‘Abbās: the earth will move from beneath it. It is the quake of the Hour, as Allah says: “Indeed, the convulsion of the Hour is a tremendous thing” (al-Ḥajj 22:1).

as-Sa‘dī

Allah tells of what will happen on the Day of Resurrection: the earth will quake so violently that everything on it falls — buildings and landmarks collapse, mountains crumble, and it becomes a level plain.

al-Jalālayn

Zulzilat: shaken for the coming of the Hour.
Zilzalahā: its mighty shaking, befitting its immensity.

Āyah 2 • It casts out its burdens



وَأَخْرَجَتِ الْأَرْضُ أَثْقَالَهَا

And the earth brings forth its burdens,

Ibn Kathīr

Athqāl: the dead within it (cf. al-Inshiqāq 84:4). He cites Muslim: the earth will throw out its pieces of liver like pillars of gold and silver. The killer, the one who cut ties of kin, and the thief will each say “For this I sinned” — then leave it, taking nothing.

as-Sa‘dī

It brings out the dead and the treasures it holds within.

al-Jalālayn

Athqālahā: its treasures and its dead, cast onto its surface.

Āyah 3 · “What is wrong with it?”



وَقَالَ الْإِنْسَانُ مَا لَهَا

And man says, “What is [wrong] with it?”

Ibn Kathīr

Man is astonished: the earth that was firm and still beneath him is now shaking and in turmoil — the inevitable command of Allah has come, and there is no escape.

as-Sa’dī

When he sees the terror that has struck it, he cries out in alarm, asking what has happened to it.

al-Jalālayn

Al-insān: the disbeliever who denied the resurrection, asking in denial and astonishment.

Āyah 4 · The earth reports its news



يَوْمَئِذٍ تُحَدِّثُ أَخْبَارَهَا

That Day, it will report its news

Ibn Kathīr

He cites at-Tirmidhī: the Prophet ﷺ asked, “Do you know what its news is?” and said: it will bear witness against every servant, male and female, about what they did on its back — “he did such-and-such on such a day.”

as-Sa‘dī

The earth will testify about the deeds done upon it, good and evil. It is one of the witnesses that will testify against servants for their deeds.

al-Jalālayn

It will tell of the good and evil that was done upon it.

Āyah 5 · Because your Lord commanded it



بِأَنَّ رَبَّكَ أَوْحَىٰ لَهَا

Because your Lord has inspired [i.e., commanded] it.

Ibn Kathīr

Awḥā lahā means awḥā ilayhā: He gave it permission and commanded it to speak (al-Bukhārī reports this from Ibn ‘Abbās).
Mujāhid: He commanded it.

as-Sa‘dī

Allah commanded it to report what was done upon it, and it does not disobey His command.

al-Jalālayn

Awḥā lahā: He commanded it to do so.

Āyah 6 · People come forth in groups



يَوْمَئِذٍ يَصْدُرُ النَّاسُ أَشْتَاتًا لِيُرَوْا أَعْمَالَهُمْ

That Day, people will depart in scattered groups to be shown their deeds.

Ibn Kathīr

They return from the place of reckoning in different kinds — wretched and happy, some taken to Paradise and some to the Fire — to be shown their deeds and recompensed for them.

as-Sa‘dī

From the place of standing they come out in separate groups, so that Allah shows them the deeds they did, good and evil.

al-Jalālayn

Ashtātan: scattered — the people of the right to Paradise, the people of the left to the Fire. Li-yuraw: to see the recompense of their deeds.

Āyah 7–8 • Not an atom is lost

7–8

فَمَنْ يَعْمَلْ مِثْقَالَ ذَرَّةٍ خَيْرًا يَرَهُ ﴿٧﴾ وَمَنْ يَعْمَلْ مِثْقَالَ ذَرَّةٍ شَرًّا يَرَهُ

So whoever does an atom's weight of good will see it, and whoever does an atom's weight of evil will see it.

Ibn Kathīr

He cites: “Protect yourselves from the Fire, even with half a date” (al-Bukhārī); “Do not belittle any good, even meeting your brother with a cheerful face” (Muslim); and the warning against sins that are taken lightly, for they gather on a person until they destroy him (Aḥmad).

as-Sa‘dī

This covers all good and all evil. If even an atom's weight is seen, then how much more what is greater. It urges doing good however small, and warns against evil however slight.

al-Jalālayn

Mithqāla dharrah: the weight of the smallest ant. Yarah: he will see its recompense.

Key words of the sūrah

zulzilat

violently shaken, convulsed

زُلْزِلَتْ

athqālahā

its burdens — the dead and treasures

أَثْقَالَهَا

akhbārahā

its news — testimony of deeds

أَخْبَارَهَا

awḥā lahā

commanded / permitted it

أَوْحَىٰ لَهَا

yaṣḍuru

departs, comes forth

يَصْدُرُ

ashtātan

in scattered, separate groups

أَشْتَاتًا

mithqāla

the weight of

مِثْقَالٍ

dharrah

a tiny ant / a speck of dust

ذَرَّةٍ

From the wider tafsīr tradition

aṭ-Ṭabarī

Records that athqāl are the dead buried in the earth, which it casts out at the Hour. On dharrah, he relays the view that it is the smallest red ant.

al-Qurṭubī

Holds that the earth's speech is real: Allah gives it the power to speak. He also relays from Ibn 'Abbās that dharrah is a speck of dust — put your hand in the earth, lift it, and each grain that clings is a dharrah.

al-Baghawī

Explains al-insān in āyah 3 as the disbeliever, since the believer already knows what is happening. Ibn Mas'ūd is reported to have called āyāt 7–8 the most decisive in the Qur'ān.

An atom's weight — both ways

مِثْقَالُ ذَرَّةٍ خَيْرًا

- Half a date given in charity (al-Bukhārī)
- A cheerful face for your brother (Muslim)
- Removing harm from the road
- A sincere word, a quiet du‘ā’

→ **Never belittle a small good**

مِثْقَالُ ذَرَّةٍ شَرًّا

- A harsh word, a careless glance
- Small sins repeated and taken lightly
- Wronging someone in a trivial amount
- Neglecting a small duty

→ **Never belittle a small sin**

Lessons to carry



The Hour is real and near

The earth itself will be overturned (āyāt 1–2).



Wealth will be worthless

Gold cast out of the earth — and no one wants it (āyah 2).



The ground is a witness

Every place you stand will testify (āyāt 4–5).



Creation obeys its Lord

The earth speaks only by His command (āyah 5).



Every deed is recorded

People are shown their deeds in full (āyah 6).



Nothing is small

Do the small good; fear the small sin (āyāt 7–8).

فَمَنْ يَعْمَلْ مِثْقَالَ ذَرَّةٍ خَيْرًا يَرَهُ

“So whoever does an atom’s weight of good will see it.” — 99:7



References

Ibn Kathīr, Tafsīr al-Qur’ān al-‘Aẓīm · as-Sa’dī, Taysīr al-Karīm ar-Raḥmān · al-Maḥallī & as-Suyūṭī, Tafsīr al-Jalālayn · aṭ-Ṭabarī, Jāmi‘ al-Bayān · al-Qurṭubī, al-Jāmi‘ li-Aḥkām al-Qur’ān · al-Baghawī, Ma‘ālim at-Tanzīl · Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 2371; Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 987, 1013